Anti-Recipes — Hip-Hop

Sounds like: what makes rap productions sound amateur

ACCURACY A

Stock Reason nails this sound.

TESTED - settings verified in a session

Starting material: any hip-hop session

DO THIS, STEP BY STEP

1. Don't let the kick and 808 fight. If both have energy at 60 Hz, you get mud, not power. Either the kick is a click that triggers the 808's attention (trap) or they're EQ-carved into separate lanes (boom-bap). Pick one relationship per song.

2. Don't drown a rap vocal in reverb. Reverb pushes voices back; rap lives in front. If it feels dry and lonely, add a short delay throw or a 0.3 s room at whisper level — not a hall.

3. Don't leave the 808 un-tuned. An 808 is a bass instrument playing notes. If those notes aren't in the song key, nothing above them can fix it. Tune first, then mix.

4. Don't stack five hi-hat loops for texture. Frequency pileup at 8–12 kHz reads as harsh noise. One programmed hat pattern with velocity variation beats five loops every time.

5. Don't master to match a Spotify rip's loudness by limiter alone. Slamming the Maximizer until the meter matches destroys the transients that make drums knock. If you can't reach the loudness cleanly, the mix (usually the low end) isn't ready for the master.

Why this works

Hip-hop's power is minimalism executed precisely — errors here are almost always "too much" rather than "too little."

The skill you just learned

Subtraction is the most-used tool in professional rap mixes.